army commander, despite having just returned from Tawang, was unaware of what was going on.

When questioned by Mullik about the strength of Tawang's defences, Bogey Sen stated that, in his opinion, they were adequate to hold out against an attack, but the divisional commander thought otherwise and had decided to withdraw to a more suitable defensive position. Sen said he had not interfered with the divisional commander's plans because by then Bum-la was already under attack and that the Chinese were closing in from all sides. Before an incredulous Mullik could question Sen further, Palit 'unobtrusively pulled him to one side and whispered that the Prime Minister had agreed to a withdrawal from Tawang should the military so decide'.

Sen started to brief the gathering on the operational plans but it soon became obvious that he was familiar neither with the terrain nor with IV Corps's operational plans. His depiction of the threats to Tawang and Bomdila was 'perfunctory and misleading'. Then Sen started to talk of future courses of action, 'waving the pointer vaguely over the sand model, saying he had directed 4 Infantry Division to hold the line of defence Jang-Dirang-Bomdila'. These were the exact words used by General Thorat two years ago and had been the most obvious flaw in his plan, for even then it should have been Mandala-Dirang-Bomdila.

With minimal ground knowledge, Thapar and Sen were torn between regrouping on the defensive line drawn by Thorat in 1960 and the Se-la massif that presented an ideal natural barrier to next engage the Chinese. This confusion is reflected in the barrage of orders that went out pertaining to 4 Artillery Brigade. Initially, they were told to withdraw from Tawang and take up position at Jang. This made no sense as Jang was too close to Tawang and, like Tawang, was on the slopes and not on higher ground. Besides, the logistical problems that had existed in supplying the garrison at Tawang were just as true for Jang. The orders were then changed and the brigade was told to fall back on Bomdila. To Palit, it was obvious that despite his relatively junior rank, he had to speak up before things went too far.

Violating all established protocols, Palit stepped forward. 'I interrupted to protest that what he [Bogey Sen] had just described was not a line of defence but a line of withdrawal. Going up to the sand model I delineated the road from Tawang to the Assam plains. On it, successively lay Jang, Dirang and Bomdila. I forbore from stressing the obvious; instead I pointed